of war,' he wrote in his letter to Kennedy on 26 October.[4] Harold Macmillan also believed that escalation was inevitable. Yet Robert McNamara did not. As noted earlier, he thought that if the United States was struck by missiles from Cuba, President Kennedy would not launch 'a full retaliatory response'. Instead, McNamara believed: 'I am certain that the President would have responded with one, or two, or maybe ten [nuclear weapons].'[5] The whole logic of reforming the SIOP, developing graduated responses to Soviet aggression against West Berlin, and later introducing the strategy of Flexible Response, demonstrated the belief that controlling and limiting a nuclear exchange was possible.

Many historians agree with Nikita Khrushchev. Recent authoritative studies believe that once the Rubicon was crossed it stayed crossed. Several have identified where exactly the River Rubicon was to be found in 1962 – in the middle of the Sargasso Sea. Martin Sherwin and Serhii Plokhy have suggested that had a Soviet submarine captain launched a nuclear-armed-torpedo at the US warships he believed were attacking him, then all-out nuclear war would have ensued. The episode is explored below.

Washington policymakers and Western strategists struggled over decades with questions of how nuclear war could be controlled (and terminated). The idea that nuclear weapons could be used in a discriminate manner pervaded Western thinking and US/NATO policy. For many years, the Soviet Union appeared to believe otherwise. The assumption in the West was that rational thought and action was still possible once the nuclear threshold was crossed.

Accidents will (or won't) happen

A starting point for discussion is how might nuclear war have started. In Nevil Shute's *On the Beach,* nuclear war begins with seemingly rational decisions. In *Dr Strangelove,* it begins with seemingly irrational decisions. In October 1962 it could have begun without any decisions. In his 2013 book *Command and Control,* Eric Schlosser provides a history of American nuclear near-misses, one of which occurred in 1961 (three days after President Kennedy's inaugural address). The accident had potentially